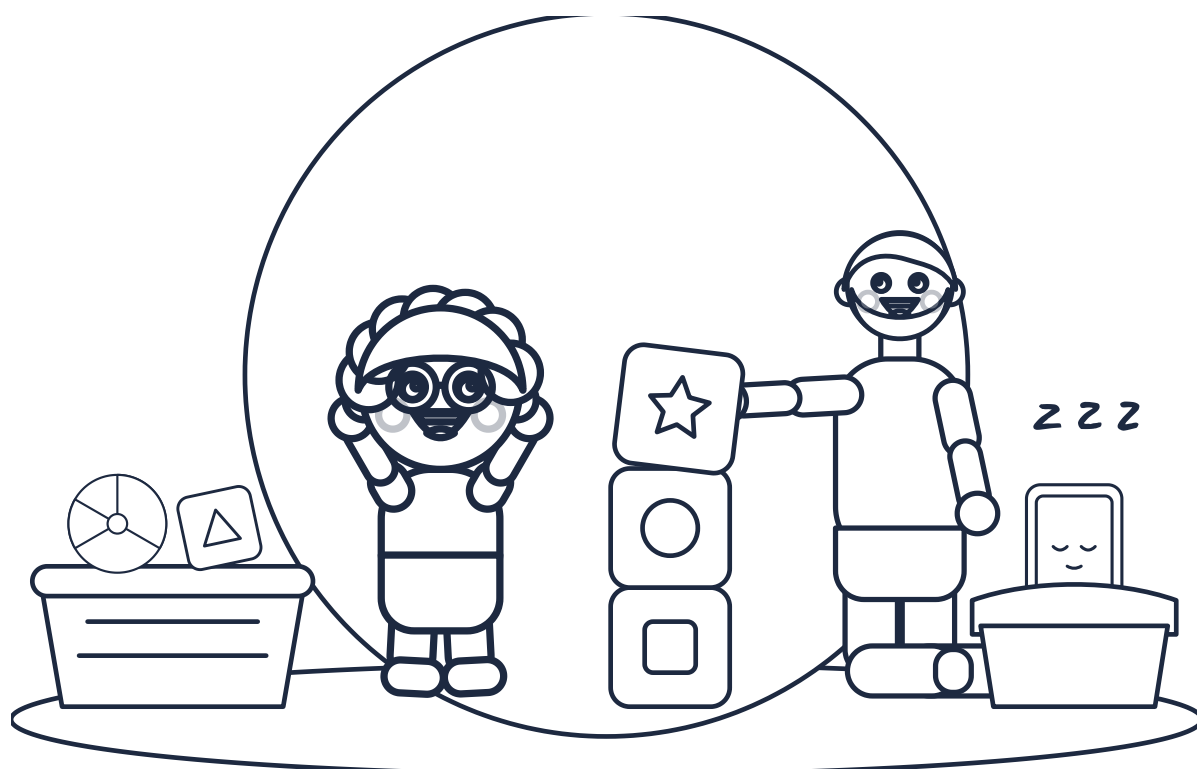


30 Days of Back-and-Forth

A play-first screen-time plan for families



30 short lessons • 30 easy plays • plain words for tricky moments

Workbook & trackers • Low-ink edition • A4 • 22 of 30 plays need no prep; the rest take about 2 minutes



Play Before Pixels

Welcome to your 30 days

This is a written, go-at-your-own-pace program. No videos, no calls, no perfect days required. We're not banning anything. We're **adding**: more play, more talk, more time face to face, and a steady spot in the day for screens.

How the program works

1. **One email a morning, for 30 days.** Each has a short lesson (about 3 minutes to read), one easy play and plain words for a tricky moment.
2. **This workbook holds the same 30 days**, plus trackers, planning pages, a scripts bank and a certificate. Use it on paper or type into it.
3. **Go at your own pace.** Miss a day? Nothing breaks. Pick up where you are. It's fine to take longer than 30 days.

Your 2-minute setup

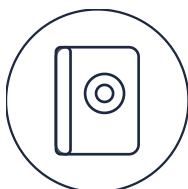
- Print pages 6–10 (or just the tracker) and put them on the fridge.
- Fill a play basket with 5–8 things you already have (page 8).
- Pick a phone parking spot for your own phone.

Printing tips

- **Letter or A4:** open the file that matches your paper and print at "Actual size" or 100%.
- **Paper:** ordinary printer paper is fine. Use card stock for the tracker and certificate if you have it.
- **Save ink:** print the Low-ink edition (white pages, line drawings your child can color).
- **Print shop:** any copy shop can print it. Laminate the tracker and use a dry-erase marker to reuse it.

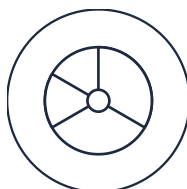
What you can type into

Open the Color or Low-ink PDF in free Adobe Acrobat Reader and click any light line to type: the planning pages, the blank tracker, the daily notes, the check-ins, your family plan, the certificate and the blank play pages. The lessons, plays and pre-filled tracker are fixed text. Save a copy to keep your notes.



Read

one short lesson, about 3 minutes



Play

one easy play with things you have



Say

plain words for one tricky moment

What this is

Parent education about everyday play and talk, for families with children aged about 1 to 5.

What this isn't

Treatment, diagnosis or advice about any one child. If you have questions about your child's development, talk with your pediatrician.

Your month at a glance

We made this program for ordinary days: the rushed mornings, the long hour before dinner and the moment the show ends. You don't need a new routine, special toys or a perfect week. You need a few minutes, a basket of things you already have, and a willingness to wait for an answer. Every day brings one idea, one play and a few words to try. Take what fits your family and leave the rest. Some days will go sideways. That's normal, and tomorrow's lesson will be waiting.

Week 1

Notice and make room

- 1 Start with one ordinary day
- 2 Why talk and play come first
- 3 Give screens a steady spot
- 4 Build a play basket
- 5 The first ten minutes
- 6 A kind ending for screen time
- 7 Week 1: keep what worked

Week 2

Play comes first

- 8 Play first, screens in their spot
- 9 Boredom is where play starts
- 10 Kitchen time is play time
- 11 Mornings without the scramble
- 12 Outside counts
- 13 Big feelings when screens end
- 14 Tired days count too

Week 3

More back-and-forth

- 15 Pause and wait
- 16 Say what you see
- 17 Repeat and add one
- 18 Offer a choice
- 19 Follow their lead
- 20 Sing, gesture and your own language
- 21 Books, paper and pages

Week 4

Make it stick

- 22 Waiting without a screen
- 23 Car rides and travel
- 24 Grown-up phones
- 25 Fairness and turns
- 26 Siblings, twins and mixed ages
- 27 Grandparents, sitters and other homes
- 28 Tough days, sick days, travel days

Days 29–30

Your family's plan

- 29 Look back: what did they ask for again?
- 30 Your family's plan

The why, in plain words

Why play and talk?

Children learn to communicate by doing it: babbling, pointing, asking and answering, with a person who answers back. Those everyday exchanges happen during play, meals, baths and car rides. This program makes a little more room for them.

Screens aren't the enemy here. They get a steady spot in the day, the same time and the same ending, so nobody has to negotiate. The rest of the day fills up with easy, ordinary play.

Three talk lines to start with

"You're stacking the red one!" (say what you see)

"Ready, set... (wait) go!" (pause and wait)

"Ball!" "Big ball!" (repeat and add one)

Talk, sing and read in the language you know best. A sign, a point, a look or a tap on a device counts as communicating.

Six easy talk moves

- 1 Pause and wait**
Say a little, then stop. Count to five in your head. A look, a sound, a sign, a point or a word all count as an answer.
- 2 Say what you see**
Put words to what your child is doing, right as it happens. No questions needed.
- 3 Repeat and add one**
Say back what your child said or showed, and add one more word or idea.
- 4 Offer a choice**
Hold up two options and wait. Reaching, pointing and looking all count.
- 5 Follow their lead**
Let your child choose what to do and how. Join in and copy them.
- 6 Sing and gesture**
Songs, rhythm and hand moves make words easy to join. Repeat the same ones often.

Good to know: most children love 2–3 of these plays far more than the rest and ask for them again and again. That's the program working. Repeat the favorites.

What counts as a turn?



A look



A point or a sign



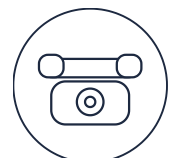
A sound or a song



A smile



A word



A tap on a talking device

Every one of these is communicating. Answer it as if it were the best thing anyone has said all day.

Safety, ages and how to read a play

✓ Every play follows our published safety rules

- A grown-up is always there. Every play in this program is played with a grown-up close by.
- For children under 3, nothing small enough to fit through a toilet-paper tube (about 1.25 in / 3.2 cm across).
- No balloons for children under 8. No cords or strings long enough to wrap around a neck.
- Water play is always supervised, however shallow the water.
- No choking-hazard foods for toddlers: whole grapes, nuts, popcorn and hard candy stay away.
- Grown-ups handle knives, the stove, hot pans, chargers and anything sharp.

You know your child best. Skip or change any play that doesn't suit your child, your home or your day.

Ages

Every play shows a starting age ("From 18 months"), a way to make it easier and a way to make it harder for preschoolers. Every week has boxes for toddlers, preschoolers, and siblings and twins.

Every child talks, plays and grows on their own timeline. If you have questions about your child's development, talk with your pediatrician.

How to read a play



Starting age

The youngest age the play usually suits.



Prep

No prep · 2-min prep · 10-min prep. No play takes longer to set up than it plays.



Mess

No mess · A little mess · Messy.



Play time

Quick · Short · Longer. A rough guide only: many children play longer or shorter.



You need

Things most homes already have. Nothing to buy.



Talk while you play

One talk line to try, and the talk move it uses.



Tired-grown-up version

Two minutes, no setup, for days when you're running on empty.

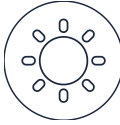


The tube test for under-3s

Try to push the object through an empty toilet-paper tube. If it fits, it's too small for a child under 3. Keep it out of the play basket and out of reach.

Our ordinary day

Walk through one ordinary day. Where do screens show up, and why? Where does play already happen? You're drawing a map, not grading yourself.

	WHAT USUALLY HAPPENS	SCREENS? WHY?	PLAY OR TALK ALREADY?
 Wake-up and breakfast			
 Morning			
 Midday and lunch			
 Afternoon			
 Before dinner			
 Evening and bedtime			

Circle the two moments when a screen helps you most. Those are the moments this program will help with first.

Our two moments:

Our screen spot

A steady spot: the same time, the same place, the same ending, every day. It doesn't grow when chores are done and doesn't shrink after a hard morning. It simply stays put.

Example

WHEN

After nap, about 3:30

WHERE

On the couch in the living room

WHAT

Two episodes of a gentle show we choose together

HOW IT ENDS

"Two more minutes" warning, the episode ends, "Night-night, tablet"

WHAT COMES NEXT (THE LANDING)

Snack, then outside to find the moon

Ours

WHEN

WHERE

WHAT

HOW IT ENDS

WHAT COMES NEXT (THE LANDING)



Our promise: screens are never a prize and never a punishment. No earning minutes, no losing minutes. The spot is just part of the day, like lunch.

1

A warning

"Two more minutes, then the tablet goes to sleep."

2

A clear ending

The episode ends or the timer rings. "Night-night, tablet."

3

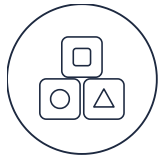
A landing

"Now we go outside and find the moon."

Tell your child: "Here's our new plan. Shows are after nap, on the couch. Two shows, then outside. Every day."

Our play basket

Five to eight things you already have, within your child's reach, near where you usually are. Keep the rest out of sight and swap a few things each week.



Something to build with

e.g. blocks, cups, boxes, tubes



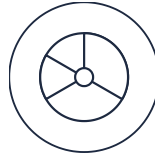
Something to pretend with

e.g. a teddy, pots, a hat, a toy phone



Something to make with

e.g. paper, crayons, tape



Something to move with

e.g. a soft ball, a cushion to climb over



Something to look at together

e.g. 2–3 books or family photos



Something that makes a sound

e.g. a pot and spoon, a shaker bottle glued shut

Swap list (things to rotate in next week)

✓ For children under 3, everything in the basket must be too big to fit through a toilet-paper tube. No cords, strings or balloons.

30 days of play

Each square is that day's play. Tick what happened. Color the star when your child asks for a play again: those are your family's favorites.

1 Say-what-you-see walk ☐ played ☐ spot kept ☐ ☆ again!	2 Narrate the snack ☐ played ☐ spot kept ☐ ☆ again!	3 Stop and go dance ☐ played ☐ spot kept ☐ ☆ again!	4 Basket surprise ☐ played ☐ spot kept ☐ ☆ again!	5 Tell me three things ☐ played ☐ spot kept ☐ ☆ again!
6 Tuck in the tablet ☐ played ☐ spot kept ☐ ☆ again!	7 Blanket hideout ☐ played ☐ spot kept ☐ ☆ again!	8 Sock basketball ☐ played ☐ spot kept ☐ ☆ again!	9 The box of anything ☐ played ☐ spot kept ☐ ☆ again!	10 Veggie wash station ☐ played ☐ spot kept ☐ ☆ again!
11 Silly sock song ☐ played ☐ spot kept ☐ ☆ again!	12 Color hunt ☐ played ☐ spot kept ☐ ☆ again!	13 Blow out the candles ☐ played ☐ spot kept ☐ ☆ again!	14 Sleeping lion ☐ played ☐ spot kept ☐ ☆ again!	15 Ready, set... go! ☐ played ☐ spot kept ☐ ☆ again!
16 Play commentator ☐ played ☐ spot kept ☐ ☆ again!	17 Add-one story ☐ played ☐ spot kept ☐ ☆ again!	18 This or that ☐ played ☐ spot kept ☐ ☆ again!	19 You're the boss ☐ played ☐ spot kept ☐ ☆ again!	20 Song basket ☐ played ☐ spot kept ☐ ☆ again!
21 Read it your way ☐ played ☐ spot kept ☐ ☆ again!	22 I spy with colors ☐ played ☐ spot kept ☐ ☆ again!	23 Window stories ☐ played ☐ spot kept ☐ ☆ again!	24 Look up together ☐ played ☐ spot kept ☐ ☆ again!	25 Paper game night ☐ played ☐ spot kept ☐ ☆ again!
26 Family restaurant ☐ played ☐ spot kept ☐ ☆ again!	27 Grandparent interview ☐ played ☐ spot kept ☐ ☆ again!	28 Cozy tray ☐ played ☐ spot kept ☐ ☆ again!	29 Favorites replay ☐ played ☐ spot kept ☐ ☆ again!	30 Family play parade ☐ played ☐ spot kept ☐ ☆ again!

No scores, no streaks to break. A blank square just means life happened.

Our own 30 days

Write in your own plays, or your child's favorites. Tick what happened and color the star when a play gets asked for again.

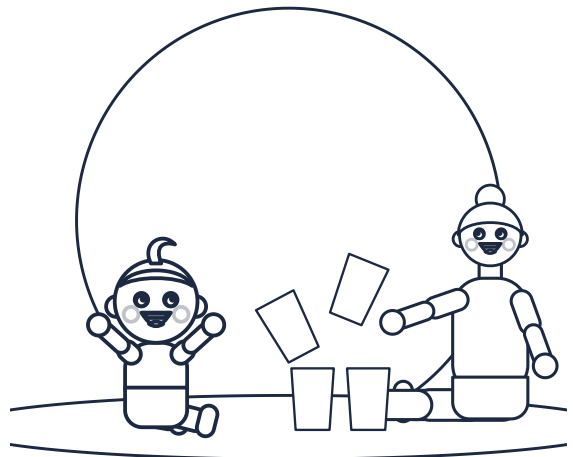
1 ☐ played ☐ spot kept ☒ again!

No scores, no streaks to break. A blank square just means life happened.

Notice and make room

This week you look at an ordinary day, give screens a steady spot and set up easy play within reach.

On one line: One steady screen spot, one play basket, ten connected minutes.



1 Start with one ordinary day

Say-what-you-see walk

3 Give screens a steady spot

Stop and go dance

5 The first ten minutes

Tell me three things

7 Week 1: keep what worked

Blanket hideout

2 Why talk and play come first

Narrate the snack

4 Build a play basket

Basket surprise

6 A kind ending for screen time

Tuck in the tablet

👶 Toddlers

Keep the screen spot short and at the same time each day. Put the play basket at their height so they can help themselves.

⚡ Preschoolers

Let them help choose what goes in the basket and draw a picture for the screen-spot plan. Helping to plan it makes it theirs.

👨👩 Siblings and twins

One shared screen spot is simpler than separate ones. Give each child one thing in the basket that is “theirs” to choose first.

💬 Plain words you'll use this week

When your child asks for a screen right now	“You want the tablet. It’s not tablet time right now.”
When someone asks why things are changing	“We’re trying something new this month: more play together.”
Telling your child about the screen spot	“Here’s our new plan. Shows are after nap, on the couch. Two shows, then outside.”
When your child says “I’m bored”	“Bored is okay. Something good usually comes next.”
Right after pickup	“I missed you. I’m so glad to see you.”
When the screen spot ends	“Two more minutes, then the tablet goes to sleep.”
When a day doesn’t go to plan (words for yourself)	“Today was a lot. Tomorrow the plan is still here.”

01

DAY 1 • WEEK 1 • NOTICE AND MAKE ROOM

Start with one ordinary day



Before you change anything, notice when screens show up in your day and when play already happens.

Welcome. For the next 30 days you'll get one short lesson, one easy play and a few plain words for a tricky moment. That's it. No videos to watch, no calls to join, no perfect days required.

This program doesn't ban anything. We're going to add: more play, more talk, more time face to face. As play grows, screens usually settle into a smaller, steadier place on their own.

Today, just notice. Pick one ordinary day, today or yesterday, and walk through it in your head. When did a screen come on? Who turned it on, and why? Maybe you needed to cook, make a call, or just breathe for ten minutes. Those are real reasons. There is nothing to feel bad about here.

Then notice the good parts. When did your child play without being asked? When did you laugh together? Where in the house does play happen most?

Write it down on the "Our ordinary day" page in your workbook, or on the back of an envelope. You're drawing a map, not grading yourself.

Many families have two or three "screen moments" that carry most of the load: the morning rush, the hour before dinner, the car. Those are the places this program will help most.

“ Plain words for: When your child asks for a screen right now

"You want the tablet. It's not tablet time right now."

"Let's look out the window and see who's outside."

Name the wish, keep it short and point to something to do. No lecture needed.



TODAY'S ONE SMALL STEP

Fill in "Our ordinary day". Circle the two moments when a screen helps you most.



🌱 From 12 months ⌚ No prep 💧 No mess ⏱ Quick play

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Why talk and play come first



The everyday back-and-forth of talk and play is how young children practice communicating.

Here is the “why” in plain words, so you can come back to it on a hard day.

Young children learn to communicate by doing it: babbling, pointing, asking, answering, all with a person who answers back. Those little exchanges are sometimes called conversational turns. They happen in ordinary moments: at breakfast, in the bath, on the floor with blocks.

The World Health Organization’s 2019 guidelines suggest no screen time for babies under 1, no more than one hour a day for children aged 2 to 4, and plenty of active play every day.

A 2024 study in JAMA Pediatrics recorded the sounds of family life at home. It found that toddlers with more screen time heard fewer words from adults and had fewer back-and-forth exchanges (Brushe and colleagues, 2024). That is a link, not proof that screens cause anything. Families are busy, and life is complicated.

But it points to something hopeful and simple: talk and play happen when we are together, face to face, with time to answer. That’s what these 30 days add.

You don’t need special toys or a script. You need a few minutes, your voice and some patience while your child takes a turn. Talk, sing and read in the language you know best. A sign, a point or a tap on a device counts as communicating too.

If you ever have questions about your child’s development, talk with your pediatrician. Every child talks on their own timeline.

“ Plain words for: When someone asks why things are changing

“We’re trying something new this month: more play together.”

“Screens aren’t going away. They’re getting a regular spot in our day.”

Keep it positive and matter-of-fact. Children and adults both relax when nothing is being taken away.



TODAY’S ONE SMALL STEP

Have breakfast or a snack together today and try the play below.



🌱 From 12 months ⌚ No prep 💧 A little mess ✂ Quick play

Sit down at the table together, no phones nearby. Say what's happening in short, cheerful sentences: pour, stir, crunch, all gone. Stop often and wait. When your child makes a sound or a word, answer it.



Make it easier

Make it harder

⚡ **Tired-grown-up version (2 minutes, no setup):** Name three foods on the plate and let your child name one.

Today's talk move: Say what you see. Put words to what your child is doing, right as it happens. No questions needed.

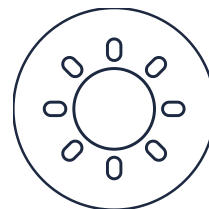
Today's notes

What happened? What did your child say, show or do?

☐ We played ☐ Screen spot kept ☒ Asked for it again

This image shows a single sheet of white paper with horizontal blue ruling lines. The lines are evenly spaced and run across the width of the page. There are no margins, text, or other markings on the paper.

Give screens a steady spot



A screen spot that happens at the same time, in the same place, with the same ending, cuts most daily negotiating.

Here is the single biggest change in this program: give screens a steady spot in your day.

A steady spot means screens happen at roughly the same time each day, in the same place, and end the same way. For example: “Shows are after nap, on the couch, for two episodes, and then we go outside.” Or: “Our show is at 4:30, in the living room, and ends when the kitchen timer rings.”

Why this works: when children know when screens come, they stop asking all day. The spot becomes like lunch. It isn’t a prize, and it isn’t a threat.

That last part matters. In this program, screens are never earned and never taken away as a punishment. They don’t grow when chores are done or shrink after a hard morning. The spot simply stays put. Linking screens to behavior tends to make them feel more valuable, and turns every day into a negotiation.

Choose a spot that fits your real life. If you need 30 minutes to cook dinner, that may be your spot. That is a sensible plan, not a failure.

The American Academy of Pediatrics (2016) suggests families make a media plan, choose shows with care, and watch together when they can. Your screen spot is the start of that plan.

“ Plain words for: Telling your child about the screen spot

“Here’s our new plan. Shows are after nap, on the couch. Two shows, then outside.”

“Every day. Same time, same place.”

Say it before the first day, when nobody is upset. Repeat it the same way each time.



TODAY’S ONE SMALL STEP

Fill in “Our screen spot”: when, where, what and how it ends. Tell your child tonight.



🌱 From 15 months ⌚ No prep 💧 No mess ⏱ Quick play

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04

DAY 4 · WEEK 1 · NOTICE AND MAKE ROOM

Build a play basket



Play starts more easily when a few good things are within reach. Fewer choices usually means more play.

Children often reach for a screen because it's the easiest "yes" in the room. Today we make play just as easy.

Find a basket, box or bag. Fill it with five to eight things you already have. Mix the kinds of play: something to build with (blocks, cups, boxes), something to pretend with (a teddy, pots, a hat), something to make with (paper, crayons), something to move with (a soft ball, a cushion to climb over), and something to look at together (two or three books).

Put the basket where your child can reach it, near where you usually are. Children like to play near their grown-ups.

Now the secret: keep the rest of the toys out of sight for now. When everything is out, children often flit from thing to thing. When there are fewer choices, they tend to settle and play longer. Every week, swap a few things in and out, and it feels new.

You don't need to buy anything. A clean sock, a wooden spoon and an empty tissue box are all play.

“ Plain words for: When your child says “I'm bored”

“Bored is okay. Something good usually comes next.”

“The basket is right there. I'll be in the kitchen if you want to show me.”

You don't have to fix boredom. Point to what's possible and give it a little time.



TODAY'S ONE SMALL STEP

Fill a play basket with 5–8 things. Put it where your child can reach it.



🌱 From 12 months ⌚ 2-min prep 💧💧 No mess ⏸ Short play

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05

DAY 5 • WEEK 1 • NOTICE AND MAKE ROOM

The first ten minutes



Ten minutes of full attention when you first see each other often makes the rest of the day easier.

The moment you pick your child up from child care, preschool or a sitter, or the moment you walk in from work, is a powerful one. Children have saved up a whole day of things to show and feel.

Many families reach for a screen right then, because everyone is tired. Today, try giving the first ten minutes to each other instead, before bags, dinner or phones.

It doesn't have to be a game. Sit on the floor. Have a snack together. Let your child show you something, or climb on you, or say nothing at all. Put your own phone somewhere else for those ten minutes.

For preschoolers, don't fire questions ("What did you do today?" often gets "Nothing"). Try sitting nearby with a snack and saying something about your own day. Many children talk more side by side: in the car, over food, while doing something with their hands.

Ten minutes of connection often makes the next hour calmer. It fills a cup that a screen can't.

“ Plain words for: Right after pickup

“I missed you. I'm so glad to see you.”

“Snack first. Then you can show me anything you like.”

Lead with warmth, not questions. The stories often come later.



TODAY'S ONE SMALL STEP

Give the first ten minutes after you reunite to your child. Phone in a bag or drawer.



🌱 From 2 years ⌚ No prep 💧💧 No mess ⌚ Quick play

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A kind ending for screen time



Most screen trouble happens at the end. A warning, a clear ending and a landing activity make it smoother.

If screens end in tears at your house, you are not alone. Stopping something fun is hard for anyone, and it's especially hard for young children, whose brakes are still developing.

Here is a three-part ending you can use every day.

First, a warning. Two minutes before the end, sit next to your child and say, "Two more minutes, then the tablet goes to sleep." Touching their shoulder or looking at the screen with them helps the warning land. Some children do better with a warning they can see, like a sand timer or two fingers held up.

Second, a clear ending. Use something outside of you: the end of an episode or a game round, a kitchen timer, a song. Then the timer is the bad guy, not you. Some families "tuck the tablet in" to a drawer or basket and say goodnight to it.

Third, a landing. Have the next thing ready and say it out loud: "Now we go outside and find the moon." Children move more easily toward something than away from something.

Expect some protest, especially this week. You don't need to argue or explain again. Stay close, stay calm and keep the ending the same every day. The ending often gets easier once it has stayed the same for a week or two.

“ Plain words for: When the screen spot ends

"Two more minutes, then the tablet goes to sleep."

"Time's up. Night-night, tablet. Now we go outside."

Same words every day. The routine does the work so you don't have to win an argument.



TODAY'S ONE SMALL STEP

Use the warning, the clear ending and the landing at today's screen spot.



🌱 From 18 months ⌚ No prep 💧 No mess ⏱ Quick play

When screen time ends, let your child switch the device off and “tuck it in” with a dish towel in its basket or drawer. Sing a tiny goodnight song together, then say what you’ll do next.



Make it easier

Make it harder

⚡ **Tired-grown-up version (2 minutes, no setup):** Just say, “Night-night, tablet,” and hold out your hand.

Today's talk move: Sing and gesture. Songs, rhythm and hand moves make words easy to join. Repeat the same ones often.

☐ We played ☐ Screen spot kept ☒ Asked for it again

Today's notes

☐ We played

☐ Screen spot kept

☒ Asked for it again

What happened? What did your child say, show or do?

Week 1: keep what worked



Look back at your first week, keep the one thing that helped most and let go of the rest.

One week done. Let's look back kindly.

Open your tracker. Don't count what you missed; look for what helped. Did the steady screen spot cut down the asking? Did the play basket get used? Did the first ten minutes change the evening?

Pick the one thing that helped most and keep doing it. If something didn't work, change it. Maybe the screen spot is at the wrong time of day. Maybe the basket needs different things. Adjusting is the program working, not failing.

Some days this week probably went sideways. Someone got sick, work ran late, or you were just done. On those days, a screen may have filled more of the day. That's okay. Tomorrow the spot is back where it lives. No making up for it, and no extra rules.

One more thing: notice what your child asked for again. A song, a play, a place in the house. Children tell us what they love by asking for it again and again. That list is gold. Write it down.

“ Plain words for: When a day doesn't go to plan (words for yourself)

“Today was a lot. Tomorrow the plan is still here.”

“I don't need a perfect day. I need a next step.”

Kindness to yourself is part of the program. Guilt tends to make the next day harder, not easier.



TODAY'S ONE SMALL STEP

Fill in the Week 1 check-in. Write down one thing to keep and one thing to change.



🌱 From 18 months ⌚ 2-min prep 💧💧 No mess ⌘ Longer play

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Look back kindly

Look for what helped, not what you missed. Adjusting the plan is the program working.

What helped most this week?

What would we change?

What did our child ask for again?

One thing we'll keep doing

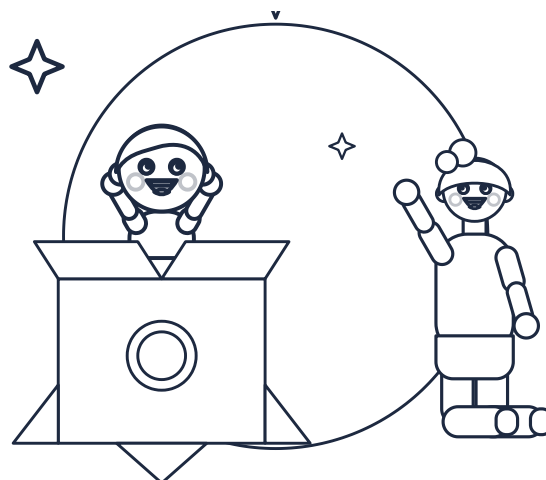


Words for yourself: “I don’t need a perfect week. I need a next step.”

Play comes first

This week play moves to the front of the day, boredom becomes a starting line and big feelings get a calm plan.

On one line: Play before the screen spot, kitchen helpers, five minutes outside.



8 Play first, screens in their spot

Sock basketball

10 Kitchen time is play time

Veggie wash station

12 Outside counts

Color hunt

14 Tired days count too

Sleeping lion

9 Boredom is where play starts

The box of anything

11 Mornings without the scramble

Silly sock song

13 Big feelings when screens end

Blow out the candles

Toddlers

Short plays, many times. Repeating the same play is part of the fun, not a sign it's "not working".

Preschoolers

Give real little jobs and simple choices. Boredom often turns into a game if you wait it out kindly.

Siblings and twins

Give the older child a "helper" role in the younger child's play, and a play of their own afterwards.

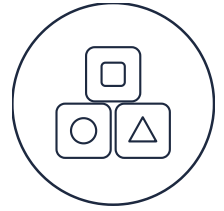
Plain words you'll use this week

"Can I have screens after this?"	"Yes. Screens are after nap, like always."
"There's nothing to do!"	"I hear you. Bored is a tricky feeling."
When you need 20 minutes to cook	"I'm making dinner. You can stir here, or play with the basket by my feet."
When getting dressed turns into a standoff	"Do you want the red socks or the stripy socks?"
"I don't want to go outside"	"Just five minutes, to check what the sky is doing."
A meltdown when the screen turns off	"You're so mad. It's hard when a show ends."
When you're too tired to play (words for your child)	"I'm very tired today. Let's do a lying-down play."

08

DAY 8 • WEEK 2 • PLAY COMES FIRST

Play first, screens in their spot



Put a short play before the screen spot so play gets the fresh energy of the day.

This week, play moves to the front.

Look at your screen spot. What happens right before it? If the answer is “waiting for it”, try putting a short play there instead. For example: after nap, ten minutes of blocks together, then shows on the couch.

Please hear this clearly: this is about the order of the day, not about earning. The screen spot happens either way, at the same time. If the play goes badly, the screen spot still happens. If the play goes brilliantly, the screen spot is still the same length. Play isn’t the price of a screen. It’s just what comes first.

Why this helps: children often play with more energy and focus before a screen than right after one. And a play that’s already going sometimes carries right through the screen spot, because your child is too busy to notice the time.

Keep it short and easy. A few minutes counts. You’re building a rhythm, not a timetable.

“ Plain words for: “Can I have screens after this?”

“Yes. Screens are after nap, like always.”

“Right now it’s play time. Your throw!”

A calm yes about the spot takes the worry out of the question. The spot is dependable.



TODAY’S ONE SMALL STEP

Put a short play right before today’s screen spot. Keep the spot the same either way.



🌱 From 18 months ⌚ No prep 💧 No mess ⏸ Short play

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Boredom is where play starts



A little boredom is normal and often turns into play if grown-ups don't rush to fill it.

Many of us feel we have to fix a bored child immediately. Today, try something different: let boredom sit for a few minutes.

Boredom is uncomfortable, and children will tell you so, loudly. But it's also the feeling right before an idea. Children who have a few minutes with nothing scheduled often start humming, building, arranging, pretending. The first few minutes are the hardest.

You can help without taking over. Keep simple, open-ended things around: boxes, paper, tape, cushions, pots, blankets, a basket of big odds and ends. Things that can be anything tend to hold attention longer than things that do one thing.

Then step back a little. Stay nearby, doing something of your own: folding laundry, cooking, reading. Children like company while they play, even if you're not playing.

If your child is truly stuck, offer one small starter ("I wonder what this box could be?") and walk away again. The idea is theirs to finish.

“ Plain words for: “There's nothing to do!”

“I hear you. Bored is a tricky feeling.”

“I'm going to fold laundry. You're welcome to help or find something in the basket.”

Empathy plus a small nudge. You're not the entertainment; you're nearby.



TODAY'S ONE SMALL STEP

Next time you hear “I'm bored”, wait five minutes before offering anything.



🌱 From 18 months ⌚ 2-min prep 💧 A little mess ⌘ Longer play

TALK WHILE YOU PLAY · Follow their lead



Preschoolers make a shop, a robot costume or a car ramp from boxes and tape, with a grown-up doing any cutting.

 **Safety:** Take off staples and packing tape first. Grown-ups do any cutting.

☐ We played ☐ Screen spot kept ☒ Asked for it again

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Kitchen time is play time



The hour before dinner is hard for everyone. Letting children help often works better than keeping them busy elsewhere.

The hour before dinner is the time many families lean on screens most. You're cooking, everyone is hungry, and patience is low. If that hour is your screen spot, keep it. That is a sensible choice.

But if you'd like another option on some days, try this: bring your child into the kitchen with you.

Children love real jobs. Toddlers can wash vegetables in a bowl of water, tear lettuce, stir cold things and put spoons on the table. Preschoolers can pour, mash, sort, count spoons and help set the table.

It will be slower and messier. It will also be full of talk: pour, stir, hot, cold, more, stop. Kitchen helping is some of the richest talk time in the day, and children feel proud of the result.

Set up a safe spot: a sturdy step with a grown-up close by, or a low table with a bowl of water and a few things to wash. Keep them well away from the stove, knives and hot pans.

“ Plain words for: When you need 20 minutes to cook

“I’m making dinner. You can stir here, or play with the basket by my feet.”

“I can talk while I cook. Tell me about your tower.”

Two choices, both near you. Talking while you work counts as connection.



TODAY'S ONE SMALL STEP

Invite your child to help with one small cooking job today.



🌱 From 18 months ⌚ 2-min prep 💧💧 Messy ⏸ Short play

Set a bowl of cool water and some whole vegetables on a towel at a low table. Your child scrubs, splashes and dries each one. Name what they're doing and each vegetable as it goes.



Make it easier

Make it harder

⚡ **Tired-grown-up version (2 minutes, no setup):** Let your child put the spoons and napkins on the table.

Today's talk move: Say what you see. Put words to what your child is doing, right as it happens. No questions needed.

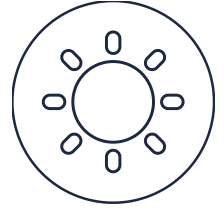
Today's notes

☐ We played ☐ Screen spot kept ☒ Asked for it again

What happened? What did your child say, show or do?

 30 Days of Back-and-Forth · Day 10

Mornings without the scramble



A short, repeatable morning order, with play in the gaps, often needs less screen help to get out the door.

Mornings are the other big screen moment. A show can buy you twenty minutes to get ready, and on some days that is exactly what you need.

If you'd like calmer mornings with less screen help, the trick is a morning order that happens the same way every day: wake up, toilet, dress, breakfast, teeth, shoes, go. When the order doesn't change, children start doing parts of it without being asked.

Picture cards help young children see what comes next. Preschoolers can help draw their own picture checklist. Keep it short: five or six steps.

Then build play into the gaps instead of rushing through them. Race the toast to the table, sing a song while shoes go on, make up a silly name for every sock. Play gets things done because children would rather join a game than follow an order.

Get one thing ready the night before: clothes, bag or breakfast bowls. Every little thing you do at night saves you minutes in the morning.

“ Plain words for: When getting dressed turns into a standoff

“Do you want the red socks or the stripy socks?”

“You do the first sock, I'll do the second. Ready?”

A choice gives your child some control, and taking turns turns a battle into a game.



TODAY'S ONE SMALL STEP

Write your morning order on one line. Tape it where your child can see it.



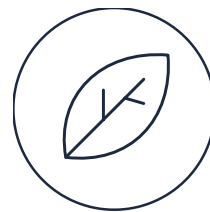
🌱 From 18 months ⌚ No prep 💧 No mess ⏱ Quick play

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12

DAY 12 • WEEK 2 • PLAY COMES FIRST

Outside counts



Even five minutes outdoors can change the mood of a day, for children and for grown-ups.

Today's idea is small and powerful: go outside, every day, even for five minutes.

Outside, children move their whole bodies, find things to name and ask about, and have space to be loud. Grown-ups often feel calmer too. A walk to the corner, a few minutes on the steps, a look at the clouds: it all counts.

The World Health Organization's 2019 guidelines suggest at least 180 minutes of physical activity spread across the day for children aged 1 to 4. That sounds like a lot, but it includes all kinds of moving: walking, climbing, dancing in the kitchen, carrying the groceries.

Weather doesn't have to stop you. Rainy days are puddle days. Cold days are short, bundled-up days. Hot days are early-morning or shade days.

If you have no yard, that's fine. Doorsteps, balconies, sidewalks, parks and the walk to the bus all count as outside.

“ Plain words for: “I don't want to go outside”

“Just five minutes, to check what the sky is doing.”

“You can bring your teddy. Teddy wants to see the clouds.”

A small, specific ask is easier to say yes to than “we're going out”.



TODAY'S ONE SMALL STEP

Spend at least five minutes outside with your child today, whatever the weather.

Big feelings when screens end



When a child melts down as screen time ends, stay close, name the feeling and keep the ending kindly in place.

Some days the ending won't be smooth, no matter what you do. Your child might cry, shout or throw themselves on the floor. That's a normal response to disappointment, especially when children are young or tired.

Here's what helps most: stay calm and stay close. You don't need to fix the feeling or talk your child out of it. You just need to keep the limit in place while the feeling passes.

Name the feeling in a few words: "You're so mad. You wanted another show." Naming it helps children feel understood, even while you hold the line.

Keep your words few. Long explanations are hard to hear when someone is upset. Say the plan once: "The tablet is asleep. It will be here tomorrow after nap."

Some children need quiet and a little space first; stay nearby. When the storm settles, reconnect: a hug if they want one, a drink of water, the landing activity you planned. There's no need for a talk about it later, unless your child wants one.

If big feelings about screens feel constant or overwhelming, or you're worried about your child, talk with your pediatrician. You don't have to handle it alone.

“ Plain words for: A meltdown when the screen turns off

"You're so mad. It's hard when a show ends."

"I'm right here. The tablet will be back tomorrow after nap."

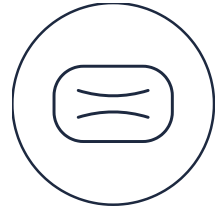
Name the feeling, keep the limit, stay close. That's all. No lecture, no threats.



TODAY'S ONE SMALL STEP

Practice today's script out loud once, so the words are ready when you need them.

Tired days count too



Low-energy play is still play. Every play in this program has a two-minute version for days like that.

Some days you won't have the energy for a fort or a kitchen project. Maybe you're unwell, didn't sleep, or had a hard day at work. That doesn't mean the day is lost.

Look at any play in this program and you'll find a "tired grown-up" version: two minutes, no setup, often lying down. Play doesn't need to be big to count. Lying on the floor while your child climbs on you is play. Reading one book with the lights low is play. Humming while your child builds is play.

Here are a few favorite lying-down plays: "doctor" (your child checks your knees with a spoon), "bridge" (you're the bridge and the cars drive under), "sleeping lion" (you pretend to sleep, they sneak up, you wake with a roar).

Also, notice this: you've reached the end of Week 2. Fill in your check-in and look for what helped most.

Resting is part of a good plan. So is using your screen spot as planned. The goal is a rhythm you can keep for years, not a perfect month.

“ Plain words for: When you're too tired to play (words for your child)

"I'm very tired today. Let's do a lying-down play."

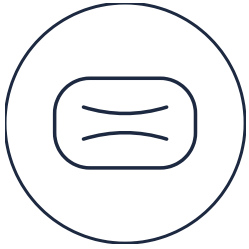
"You be the doctor. Check my knees!"

Honesty about your energy, plus an invitation. Children usually love a grown-up who lies on the floor.



TODAY'S ONE SMALL STEP

Fill in the Week 2 check-in. Try one lying-down play.



TODAY'S PLAY

Sleeping lion

🌱 From 18 months ⌚ No prep 💧 No mess ⏱ Quick play

You need: a rug or cushions

Lie down on the floor and pretend to be a sleeping lion. Your child tiptoes close. Wait... wait... then wake up with a gentle roar and a tickle. Swap: now your child is the lion.

TALK WHILE YOU PLAY · Pause and wait



“Shhh... the lion is sleeping... (wait) ... ROAR!”

Make it easier

Pretend to snore and let your toddler wake you with a pat.

Make it harder

Preschoolers play “statues”: you open your eyes and anyone moving has to freeze.

⚡ **Tired-grown-up version (2 minutes, no setup):** Just lie there and snore. That's the whole play.

 **Safety:** Play on a soft rug away from furniture edges. Keep the roar soft, tickle only if your child enjoys it, and stop the moment your child says or shows stop.

Today's talk move: Pause and wait. Say a little, then stop. Count to five in your head. A look, a sound, a sign, a point or a word all count as an answer.

Today's notes

☐ We played ☐ Screen spot kept ☒ Asked for it again

What happened? What did your child say, show or do?

This image shows a single sheet of white paper with horizontal blue ruling lines. The lines are evenly spaced and run across the width of the page. There are no margins, text, or other markings on the paper.

Look back kindly

Look for what helped, not what you missed. Adjusting the plan is the program working.

What helped most this week?

What would we change?

What did our child ask for again?

One thing we'll keep doing

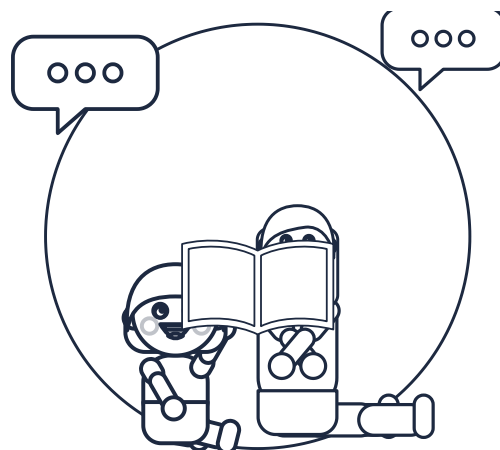


Words for yourself: “I don’t need a perfect week. I need a next step.”

More back-and-forth

This week you practice one easy talk move a day. Each one fits into the play and the chores you already do.

On one line: Pause and wait, say what you see, repeat and add one, follow their lead, sing, gesture and your own language, add one, offer a choice, follow their lead, sing.



15 Pause and wait

Ready, set... go!

17 Repeat and add one

Add-one story

19 Follow their lead

You're the boss

21 Books, paper and pages

Read it your way

16 Say what you see

Play commentator

18 Offer a choice

This or that

20 Sing, gesture and your own language

Song basket

👉 Toddlers

A sound, a sign, a point, a look or a device tap all count as communicating. Talk in the language you know best.

⚡ Preschoolers

The same moves grow into “tell me more” and “what happened next?” at meals, at bath time and in the car.

👨👩 Siblings and twins

Take turns being the “talker” and the “listener”. A younger child's turn can be a point or a sound.

💬 Plain words you'll use this week

When your child doesn't answer

(Wait. Smile. Count to five in your head.)

Instead of quizzing

Instead of “What color is that?” try “You picked the red one.”

Instead of correcting

Child: “Doggy go.” You: “Yes! The doggy's going. Going home.”

When your child wants both

“You want both! Pick one now. The other one is for after lunch.”

When their play seems “wrong”

(Instead of fixing it) “The cars are on the table! They're having a party?”

When you feel silly singing

(To yourself) “My child doesn't need a good singer. They need me.”

When they want the same book again (and again)

“Again? Yes! This is a good one.”

15

DAY 15 • WEEK 3 • MORE BACK-AND-FORTH

Pause and wait



Leaving a real pause after you speak gives children time to take their turn.

This week, one simple talk move each day. They all fit into the play you're already doing.

Today: pause and wait.

Grown-ups talk fast and fill silences, especially when we're busy. But children, especially young ones, often need a few seconds to get a word, a sound or a gesture ready. If we jump in too soon, we take their turn without meaning to.

So: say something, then stop. Count to five slowly in your head. Look at your child with an expectant, friendly face, like you're waiting for the punchline. Often, something comes: a look, a point, a sound, a word.

Whatever comes, answer it as if it were the best thing anyone has said all day. That's a turn. That's conversation.

The pause works in songs too, in any language: "Twinkle, twinkle, little..." then wait. Or in games: "Ready, set..." and wait for your child to say or sign "Go!"

It feels strange at first. Keep going. It may turn out to be the move that surprises you most.

Plain words for: When your child doesn't answer

(Wait. Smile. Count to five in your head.)

"You're thinking. I'll wait." Then answer any look, point or sound.

No pressure, no testing. The pause is an invitation, not a quiz.



TODAY'S ONE SMALL STEP

Use a five-second pause at least three times today.



🌱 From 12 months ⌚ No prep 💧 No mess ⏱ Quick play

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Describing what your child is doing gives them words without asking them to perform.

A lot of grown-up talk to children is questions: “What color is that? What does a cow say? What’s this?” Questions have their place, but too many can feel like a test, and children often go quiet.

Try this instead: say what you see. Like a friendly sports commentator, put words to what your child is doing right now. “You’re stacking. Up, up. The red one’s on top. Oh, it wobbled!”

You aren’t asking for anything back. You’re giving your child the words for their own actions at the exact moment they care about them. That’s when words stick.

Keep your sentences short, a little longer than your child’s own. If your child uses single words, use two or three. If they use short sentences, add a little more.

Preschoolers enjoy this too, in a different way: “You’ve been working on that drawing a long time. You added a door.” It tells them you’re paying attention.

“ Plain words for: Instead of quizzing

Instead of “What color is that?” try “You picked the red one.”

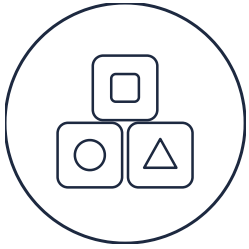
Instead of “What’s this?” try “A spoon. You’re banging the spoon.”

Commenting keeps talk flowing; quizzing often stops it.



TODAY’S ONE SMALL STEP

For five minutes, narrate your child’s play without asking a single question.



TODAY'S PLAY

Play commentator

🌱 From 12 months ⌚ No prep 💧 No mess ⌚ Short play

 You need: blocks, cups or boxes

Sit beside your child while they build or play. Describe what they do, like a friendly sports commentator. Stay on their level and keep your hands mostly still: it's their game.



TALK WHILE YOU PLAY · Say what you see

“Another block... and another... it’s so tall! Crash!”

Make it easier

Use single words: "Up. Up. Crash!"

Make it harder

Preschoolers commentate your building, or you both commentate a race between teddies.

⚡ **Tired-grown-up version (2 minutes, no setup):** Commentate from the couch: “And she’s walking to the basket...”

 **Safety:** For under-3s, blocks and cups must be too big to fit through a toilet-paper tube.

Today's talk move: Say what you see. Put words to what your child is doing, right as it happens. No questions needed.

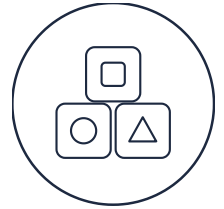
Today's notes

☐ We played ☐ Screen spot kept ☆ Asked for it again

What happened? What did your child say, show or do?

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Repeat and add one



When your child says or shows something, say it back and add one more word or idea.

Today's move grows your child's words from the ones they already use.

When your child says or shows something, say it back, and add one more word or idea. If your toddler says "Ball!", you say "Big ball!" If your preschooler says "The dog is running," you say "The dog is running fast! He wants the stick."

This does two things. It tells your child "I heard you", which makes them want to keep talking. And it shows them the next step, just a little further along.

If your child says a word in a way that isn't quite right, don't correct them. Just say it back the right way, warmly: "Nana!" "Yes, banana. A yellow banana." They hear the model without feeling wrong.

For preschoolers, it becomes "tell me more": "You went down the big slide? What happened at the bottom?"

Talk in the language you know best. The richest talk is the talk that feels natural to you.

“ Plain words for: Instead of correcting

Child: "Doggy go." You: "Yes! The doggy's going. Going home."

Child: "I goed." You: "You went! You went down the big slide."

Say it back the right way, warmly. No "say it properly".



TODAY'S ONE SMALL STEP

Every time your child says or shows something today, try to add one word.



🌱 From 2½ years ⌚ No prep 💧 No mess ⌘ Short play

You need: a picture book or family photo



“Cat.” “A sleepy cat!” “Sleepy cat in a hat!”

Name one picture and add one word: "Dog." "Big dog."

Preschoolers build a story with you, one sentence each, and add a silly twist.

 Safety: Use sturdy board books with young children; paper pages can tear into mouth-sized bits.

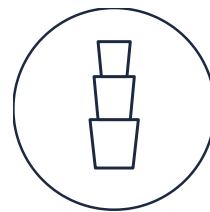
☐ We played ☐ Screen spot kept ☆ Asked for it again

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18

DAY 18 • WEEK 3 • MORE BACK-AND-FORTH

Offer a choice



Holding up two options and waiting gives even very young children a clear way to take a turn.

Today: offer a choice.

Hold up two things (two snacks, two books, two cups) and name them: “Apple or banana?” Then wait. Even a baby can answer by looking or reaching. A toddler might point or try the word. A preschooler might tell you why.

Choices give children a real, easy turn in the conversation, and a little control over their day. Children who feel some control often push back less on the things they don’t get to choose.

Keep choices small and real. Both options should be fine with you. “Do you want to get dressed?” isn’t a real choice; “Red shirt or blue shirt?” is.

Hold things up where your child can see both. Say the last option with a little lift in your voice. Then wait, patiently.

For preschoolers, choices can be bigger: “Park or library after lunch?” or “Should Saturday be pancake day or waffle day?”

🗨️ Plain words for: When your child wants both

“You want both! Pick one now. The other one is for after lunch.”

“You choose, or I’ll choose. Which?”

A calm limit with a choice inside it. The second choice goes to you only if they don’t pick.



TODAY’S ONE SMALL STEP

Offer at least five real two-way choices today, and wait for each answer.



🌱 From 12 months ⌚ No prep 💧 No mess ⌚ Quick play

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Follow their lead



When the child chooses the play and the grown-up joins in, children often talk and play more.

Today, let your child be the boss of the play.

For ten minutes, whatever your child wants to play, you join in. If they line up cars, you line up cars. If they put a teddy to bed, you whisper “goodnight, teddy”. If they bang a pot, you bang a pot, and then wait.

It sounds simple, but it’s hard for grown-ups. We want to teach, correct, improve: “Cars go on the road, not the table.” Today, resist. Their way is the right way for these ten minutes.

When you follow a child’s lead, you are talking about exactly what they are interested in, right when they’re interested. That’s often when the most talk happens.

Get down to their level, face to face if you can. Copy what they do. Say what you see. Pause and wait. You’re using all this week’s moves at once.

Preschoolers love this too. Let them teach you a game they made up or how to draw their favorite animal.

“ Plain words for: When their play seems “wrong”

(Instead of fixing it) “The cars are on the table! They’re having a party?”

“Show me how it works.”

Curiosity instead of correction keeps your child talking and in charge.



TODAY’S ONE SMALL STEP

Give your child ten minutes to lead the play. Copy, comment and wait.



🌱 From 12 months ⌚ No prep 💧 A little mess ⏸ Short play

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20

Sing, gesture and your own language



Songs, rhymes and gestures make words easy to join in with, in any language.

Today: sing.

You don't need a good voice. Children love their grown-ups' singing, off-key and all. Songs slow words down, repeat them and add rhythm, which makes them easier to join in with. Gestures (clapping, waving, the actions in action songs) give children a way to join before they have the words.

Pick two or three songs and sing them often: at bath time, in the car, while you wait. Repeat, repeat, repeat. Then pause before a familiar word and let your child fill it in with a sound, a sign or a word.

Sing in the language you know best, or in every language your family speaks. Lullabies from your childhood count. Songs you make up about brushing teeth count. It all counts.

Use gestures when you talk, too: point, wave, nod, show "big" with your arms. Signs and gestures are real communication, and many children use them on the way to words or alongside them.

Plain words for: When you feel silly singing

(To yourself) "My child doesn't need a good singer. They need me."

"I don't know all the words. Let's make them up!"

Your voice is the one your child most wants to hear.



TODAY'S ONE SMALL STEP

Choose two family songs. Sing each at least twice today.

Books, paper and pages



Sharing books and paper together is one of the easiest ways to add talk to the day.

Today: books and paper.

Reading together doesn't have to mean reading every word. With young children, "reading" can mean pointing at pictures, naming things, making the animal sounds, and letting your child turn the pages whenever they like. Talk about the pictures. Wait for your child to point. Follow their lead to the page they love.

Read the same book again and again if your child asks. Repetition is how children learn a story well enough to join in.

Paper books have one more thing going for them. A review of 54 studies found that readers tended to understand informational text a little better on paper than on screens (Delgado and colleagues, 2018). Those studies were with older readers, not toddlers, but whatever the format, reading together is a chance to talk.

Paper play counts too: drawing, scribbling, making lists, writing cards to grandparents, folding paper boats.

This is also the end of Week 3. Fill in your check-in: which talk move felt most natural?

“ Plain words for: When they want the same book again (and again)

“Again? Yes! This is a good one.”

“This time, you say the last word.”

Repeating is how children learn to join in. Turn repeats into turns.



TODAY'S ONE SMALL STEP

Share one book in the way your child likes. Fill in the Week 3 check-in.



🌱 From 6 months ⌚ No prep 💧 No mess ⌘ Short play

playbeforepixels.com · Version 1.0 · September 2026 **57**

Look back kindly

Look for what helped, not what you missed. Adjusting the plan is the program working.

What helped most this week?

What would we change?

What did our child ask for again?

One thing we'll keep doing

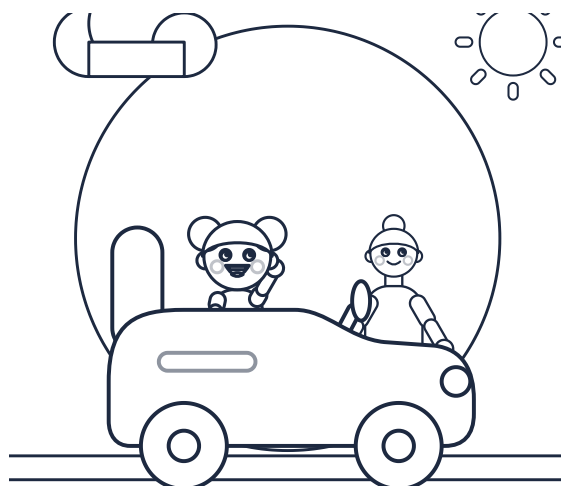


Words for yourself: "I don't need a perfect week. I need a next step."

Make it stick

This week you take the plan out into real life: waiting rooms, car rides, grown-up phones, other homes and hard days.

On one line: Pocket plays for waiting, a phone parking spot, a kind word for other caregivers, a plan for tough days.



22

Waiting without a screen

I spy with colors

24

Grown-up phones

Look up together

26

Siblings, twins and mixed ages

Family restaurant

28

Tough days, sick days, travel days

Cozy tray

23

Car rides and travel

Window stories

25

Fairness and turns

Paper game night

27

Grandparents, sitters and other homes

Grandparent interview

Toddlers

Pocket plays and songs work best for waiting. Keep them short and silly.

Preschoolers

This is the week for simple talks about turns and fairness: "Everyone gets a turn, and yours is next." Listen first.

Siblings and twins

In waiting places, give each child a job (the counter, the spotter, the storyteller).

Plain words you'll use this week

"Can I have your phone?" while waiting

"My phone is staying in my bag. Let's play I spy until the food comes."

"Are we there yet?"

"Not yet. Let's count ten red cars, then I'll tell you how far."

When your child sees you on your phone

"I'm checking the weather for tomorrow. Done! Phone's going in its spot."

"Everyone else gets to!"

"It might be true that lots of kids do. In our family, shows have a set time."

When siblings fight over whose turn it is

"Two kids, one truck. That's hard. Timer turns: you first, then you."

Talking to a grandparent or sitter

"We're trying more play at home. Here are three things she loves right now."

On a sick or travel day

"You're sick today, so it's a cozy movie day. Tomorrow we go back to our usual plan."

Waiting without a screen



A few pocket plays that need nothing at all turn waiting rooms, lines and restaurants into talk time.

This week we take the plan out into the world, starting with waiting.

Waiting is hard for young children. In doctors' offices, restaurant booths and long lines, a phone can feel like the only thing that works. Sometimes it is, and that's okay. But it helps to have a few pocket plays ready first.

Pocket plays need nothing but you: I spy, finger puppets, clapping games, "What's in my pocket?", drawing on a napkin, counting red things, guessing what the waiter will bring. Keep them short and silly and switch often.

A few things make waiting easier. Feed hungry children first (a snack in your bag solves a lot). Tell your child what will happen: "We'll wait, then the doctor will look in your ears." And lower your expectations: wriggly is normal.

Preschoolers can bring a small notebook and a chunky crayon for waiting. Drawing games travel anywhere.

“ Plain words for: “Can I have your phone?” while waiting

“My phone is staying in my bag. Let's play I spy until the food comes.”

“You can pick: I spy or napkin drawing?”

A clear, friendly no plus a choice. If you do decide to hand over the phone, that's your call; say so plainly.



TODAY'S ONE SMALL STEP

Pick three pocket plays to keep in your back pocket. Write them on your phone's lock screen or a card in your bag.



🌱 From 2½ years ⌚ No prep 💧 No mess ⚡ Quick play

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Cars, buses and trains are some of the best places to talk, because nobody has to look at anybody.

The car (or bus, or train) is one of the best talking places in family life. Everyone is side by side, nobody has to make eye contact, and there's always something going past the window.

Try a few quiet minutes with no screens and see what happens. Start with a game: count cows, spot yellow cars, sing a song with a silly ending, tell a story one sentence each.

For longer trips, pack a small bag of things to do: a notebook, a favorite small toy (big enough for little ones), a book, a snack. Plan stops to move bodies.

If you use screens on long trips, give them a steady spot there too: "Shows after the first stop, until lunch." Same idea as at home, and it cuts the asking.

Some of the best conversations of childhood happen staring out of a window. Leave room for them.

“ Plain words for: “Are we there yet?”

“Not yet. Let's count ten red cars, then I'll tell you how far.”

“About two songs long. Which song first?”

Turn time into something a child can picture: songs, cars, stops.



TODAY'S ONE SMALL STEP

Try the first ten minutes of your next ride without a screen, with a game or a song.



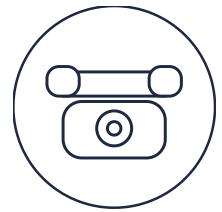
🌱 From 2½ years ⌚ No prep 💧 No mess ⌘ Short play



24

DAY 24 • WEEK 4 • MAKE IT STICK

Grown-up phones



Children notice our screens too. A phone parking spot and a few spoken habits help the whole family.

This lesson is about us, the grown-ups, and it comes with zero guilt. Phones are where our work, our bills, our friends and our news live. Of course we check them.

Children notice, though. When a grown-up looks at a phone, conversation often pauses, and young children may not know why.

Three small habits help.

A phone parking spot. Choose a place (a shelf, a basket, a drawer) where your phone lives during play time, meals and the first ten minutes after you reunite. Out of sight, out of hand.

Say it out loud. When you do need your phone, tell your child what you're doing: "I'm checking the bus time. Done." It shows that phones are tools, and you come back.

Pick one phone-free window. Dinner, bath time or the bedtime routine. Just one, every day.

You don't need to be perfect. Children learn more from how we come back to them than from how often we get distracted.

🗨️ Plain words for: When your child sees you on your phone

"I'm checking the weather for tomorrow. Done! Phone's going in its spot."

"Give me one minute to finish this message, then I'm all yours."

Naming what you're doing and coming back is the habit children copy.



TODAY'S ONE SMALL STEP

Choose a phone parking spot and one phone-free window every day.



🌱 From 18 months ⌚ No prep 💧 No mess ⏱ Quick play

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25

DAY 25 • WEEK 4 • MAKE IT STICK

Fairness and turns



Young children care a lot about fairness. Listening first makes the family plan feel like theirs.

Sooner or later you'll hear it: "That's not fair!" or "But she got a turn!" Even very young children care a lot about fairness and about what other children have.

Those are healthy things to care about. So today is about listening first.

At a calm time, not in the middle of a meltdown, ask: "What do you love about your show? What else would you like to do more of?" Then really listen. A point, a picture or one word is a full answer.

Then explain your family's plan plainly and without fear stories: "In our family, shows have a set time, and the rest of the day is for other things we love." You can agree that other families do it differently. Families are different.

Give your preschooler a real say in the small details: which show, which day is movie night, who presses the off button. Children tend to follow plans they helped make.

And keep inviting them into things that feel grown-up: stirring the soup, choosing the park, carrying the library books.

🗨️ **Plain words for: "Everyone else gets to!"**

"It might be true that lots of kids do. In our family, shows have a set time."

"I want to hear what you think. Let's talk about it at dinner."

Agree with what's true, hold your plan and promise a real conversation later.



TODAY'S ONE SMALL STEP

Have a calm, listening talk with your child about the family plan.



🌱 From 4 years ⌚ No prep 💧 No mess ⌚ Longer play

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One family rhythm, with roles for each child, works better than separate plans for everyone.

If you have more than one child, the plan has to work for everyone at once. Here are some ideas that help.

Keep one shared screen spot. Separate spots for each child are hard to keep up with and invite arguments.

Give roles, not just turns. In a pretend restaurant, one child is the chef, one is the waiter, one is the customer. In a block game, one builds and one decorates. Roles let different ages play together without constant competition.

Protect a little one-on-one time. Even five minutes alone with each child, doing what they choose, makes shared time easier.

Twins and close-in-age siblings often need their own basket or their own “first pick”. Take turns being first.

And let an older sibling help a younger one, if they want to. Being the expert makes children proud.

Plain words for: When siblings fight over whose turn it is

“Two kids, one truck. That’s hard. Timer turns: you first, then you.”

“While you wait, you can be the driver’s helper.”

Name the problem, give a fair system and a job for the waiting child.



TODAY’S ONE SMALL STEP

Try one play today where each child has a different role.



🌱 From 2 years ⌚ 2-min prep 💧 A little mess ⌘ Longer play

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Grandparents, sitters and other homes



Share your plan with other caregivers warmly, then let other homes be different.

Children spend time with grandparents, sitters, co-parents and friends. Each home is a little different, and that's fine. Children are good at understanding that different places have different rules.

If you want other caregivers to join in, share the plan warmly and simply, without asking them to change everything. For example: "We're trying more play at home. She loves these three games right now, if you want ideas." A short list of favorite plays is usually more welcome than a list of rules.

Make it easy: leave the play basket, a book, some paper and crayons. Share your screen-spot words so the ending sounds the same.

Then let go a little. A grandparent who watches a movie with your child on a Saturday is still spending time with them, side by side. That's connection too.

Grandparents can be great play partners: stories from their childhood, old songs, cooking, card games and letters by mail.

“ Plain words for: Talking to a grandparent or sitter

"We're trying more play at home. Here are three things she loves right now."

"When shows finish, we say 'Night-night, tablet'. It helps if it sounds the same."

Invite, don't instruct. Ideas and shared words travel better than rules.



TODAY'S ONE SMALL STEP

Share a short list of your child's favorite plays with another caregiver.



Grandparent interview

You need: paper and a pencil, or a phone call on speaker

TALK WHILE YOU PLAY · Repeat and add one



Look at an old family photo and name the people and things in it.

Preschoolers draw a picture letter back and help mail it.

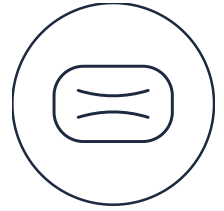
 Safety: No cords or strings near young children. Grown-ups hold phones on speaker for little ones.

Today's notes

What happened? What did your child say, show or do?

This image shows a single sheet of white paper with horizontal blue ruling lines. The lines are evenly spaced and run across the width of the page. There are no margins, text, or other markings on the paper.

Tough days, sick days, travel days



A planned change for a hard day is fine. Say it out loud, and go back to your usual rhythm the next day.

Some days the plan will bend. A sick child on the couch. A long flight. A day when you are the one who is unwell. A work deadline. On those days, screens may fill more of the day.

That's okay. A planned change for a hard day is not a failure, and it doesn't undo anything. Two things make it work.

Say it out loud. "You're sick today, so we're having a cozy movie day on the couch together. Tomorrow we go back to our usual plan." When it's spoken as a special exception, children understand it's not the new normal.

Go back the next day. No "making up for it", no less screen time as a correction. Just the usual spot, in its usual place.

Remember: a sick day isn't about behavior, so this doesn't break the rule that screens don't grow or shrink with chores or behavior. It's about what your family needs that day.

Quiet plays help on sick days too: stories, drawing in bed, a basket of books, watching the rain.

Plain words for: On a sick or travel day

"You're sick today, so it's a cozy movie day. Tomorrow we go back to our usual plan."

"Long flight today! Shows after the first snack."

Naming the exception keeps it an exception.



TODAY'S ONE SMALL STEP

Write your "tough day plan" in the workbook: what a cozy day looks like, and the words for going back.

Our tough-day plan

A planned change for a hard day is fine. Say it out loud, and go back to your usual rhythm the next day. No making up for it.

What a cozy day looks like at our house

Our quiet plays for sick or tired days

What we'll say about the change

How we go back tomorrow

Example: “You’re sick today, so it’s a cozy movie day on the couch together. Tomorrow we go back to our usual plan.”

Look back kindly

Look for what helped, not what you missed. Adjusting the plan is the program working.

What helped most this week?

What would we change?

What did our child ask for again?

One thing we'll keep doing



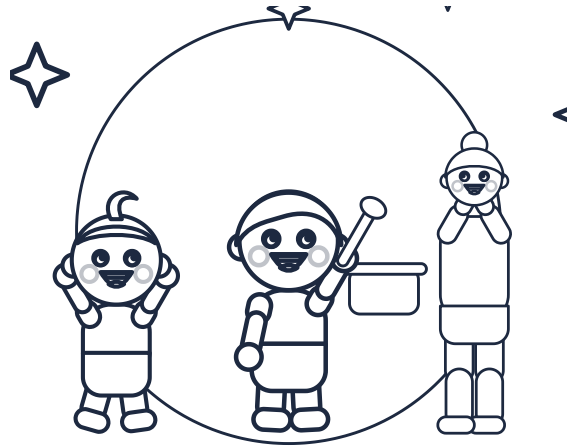
Words for yourself: “I don’t need a perfect week. I need a next step.”

DAYS 29–30 · DAYS 29–30

Your family's plan

Two days to look back, keep what worked and write a simple plan you can live with.

On one line: Your screen spot, your favorite plays, your words for tricky moments.



29

Look back: what did they ask for again?

Favorites replay

30

Your family's plan

Family play parade

Toddlers

The plays they asked for again are your plan. Write those down first.

Preschoolers

Make the plan together with drawings and let them sign it with a scribble or a sticker. Look at it again in a month.

Siblings and twins

One family plan, with one line for each child's favorite play.

○ Your one-page plan will have five parts

1. Your screen spot: when, where, what and how it ends
2. Your two or three favorite plays, plus one new one
3. Your words for tricky moments
4. Your phone parking spot and one phone-free window
5. Your tough-day plan

Then print the certificate, let your child decorate it and put it on the fridge.

“ Plain words you'll use this week

Asking your child what they liked

“What was the most fun thing we played this month?”

Explaining the family plan going forward

“This is our family's plan. Screens after nap, and lots of play.”

29

Look back: what did they ask for again?



The plays your child asked for again are your family's real plan. Write them down.

Nearly there. Today, look back over the month.

Open your tracker and your check-ins. Circle every play your child asked for again. Most children love two or three plays far more than the rest, and they return to them over and over. Those are your family's favorites, and they're the heart of your plan.

Then look at the tricky moments. Which ones got easier? The end of screen time? The morning scramble? The hour before dinner? Which words from the scripts did you actually use?

And look at yourself. What surprised you? Maybe it was how much talking happened once there was a little more room for it. Maybe it was how little your child minded, once the screen spot was steady.

Whatever you notice, write it down. You'll use it tomorrow.

Every child talks, plays and grows on their own timeline. If you have questions about your child's development, talk with your pediatrician.

Plain words for: Asking your child what they liked

"What was the most fun thing we played this month?"

"What should we play more of?"

Children are experts on their own fun. Their answer is your plan.



TODAY'S ONE SMALL STEP

Circle your child's top three plays and your three most useful scripts.



🌱 From 12 months ⌚ No prep 💧 A little mess ⏸ Short play

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30

DAY 30 • YOUR PLAN • YOUR FAMILY'S PLAN

Your family's plan



Write a short, kind plan you can keep: your screen spot, your favorite plays and your words for tricky moments.

Day 30. You did it: thirty days of adding play and talk to real family life.

Today, write your family's plan on one page. Keep it short enough to stick on the fridge.

Our screen spot: when, where, what and how it ends.

Our favorite plays: the two or three your child keeps asking for, plus one new one to try next month.

Our words for tricky moments: the lines that worked for the end of screen time, for waiting, and for "I'm bored".

Our phone parking spot and our one phone-free window.

Our tough-day plan.

Then celebrate. Print the certificate, let your child decorate it and put it somewhere everyone can see.

Look at the plan again in a month and adjust. Families change, children grow, and the plan should grow with them. This month isn't a finish line; it's a rhythm you now know how to find.

Thank you for letting us be part of your month.

“ Plain words for: Explaining the family plan going forward

“This is our family's plan. Screens after nap, and lots of play.”

“We'll look at it again next month and change what we need to.”

A plan that can change is a plan that lasts.



TODAY'S ONE SMALL STEP

Write your one-page family plan. Print and decorate the certificate.



TODAY'S PLAY

Family play parade

🌱 From 12 months ⌚ 2-min prep 💧 A little mess ⌛ Short play

You need: pots and spoons, hats, anything that makes a parade

Celebrate with a parade around your home: bang pots, wear hats, sing your family songs from this month. Each child leads for one lap. Finish by putting your certificate on the fridge.



TALK WHILE YOU PLAY · Sing and gesture

“Left, right, bang, bang! Who leads next?”

Make it easier

Carry your toddler and bang a spoon together.

Make it harder

Preschoolers make up a family song and conduct the band.

⚡ **Tired-grown-up version (2 minutes, no setup):** March your fingers across the table and hum.

 Safety: March on a clear floor, away from stairs, and keep the noise kind to little ears.

Today's talk move: Sing and gesture. Songs, rhythm and hand moves make words easy to join. Repeat the same ones often.

Today's notes

☐ We played ☐ Screen spot kept ☒ Asked for it again

What happened? What did your child say, show or do?

This image shows a blank sheet of white paper with horizontal blue ruling lines. The lines are evenly spaced and run across the width of the page. There are no margins, text, or other markings on the paper.

Our family's plan

Short enough for the fridge. Look at it again in a month and change what you need to.

Our screen spot (when, where, what, how it ends)

Our favorite plays (and one new one to try)

Our words for tricky moments

Our phone parking spot and phone-free window

Our tough-day plan

Signed by everyone in our family _____ Date _____



This certificate is awarded to

for finishing

30 Days of Back-and-Forth

30 days of more play, more talk and a steady spot for screens.

Our favorite play: _____

Date: _____



Play Before Pixels

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Put it on the fridge. If you share a photo, we'd love to see it: #PlayBeforePixels. Please leave out your child's name and face.

Plain words for tricky moments

Every script from the 30 days, plus extras, in one place. Cut out the ones you need and keep them where the tricky moment happens.

When your child asks for a screen right now Day 1

"You want the tablet. It's not tablet time right now."
"Let's look out the window and see who's outside."

When someone asks why things are changing Day 2

"We're trying something new this month: more play together."
"Screens aren't going away. They're getting a regular spot in our day."

Telling your child about the screen spot Day 3

"Here's our new plan. Shows are after nap, on the couch. Two shows, then outside."
"Every day. Same time, same place."

When your child says "I'm bored" Day 4

"Bored is okay. Something good usually comes next."
"The basket is right there. I'll be in the kitchen if you want to show me."

Right after pickup Day 5

"I missed you. I'm so glad to see you."
"Snack first. Then you can show me anything you like."

When the screen spot ends Day 6

"Two more minutes, then the tablet goes to sleep."
"Time's up. Night-night, tablet. Now we go outside."

When a day doesn't go to plan (words for yourself) Day 7

"Today was a lot. Tomorrow the plan is still here."
"I don't need a perfect day. I need a next step."

"Can I have screens after this?" Day 8

"Yes. Screens are after nap, like always."
"Right now it's play time. Your throw!"

"There's nothing to do!" Day 9

"I hear you. Bored is a tricky feeling."
"I'm going to fold laundry. You're welcome to help or find something in the basket."

When you need 20 minutes to cook Day 10

"I'm making dinner. You can stir here, or play with the basket by my feet."
"I can talk while I cook. Tell me about your tower."

When getting dressed turns into a standoff Day 11

"Do you want the red socks or the stripy socks?"
"You do the first sock, I'll do the second. Ready?"

"I don't want to go outside" Day 12

"Just five minutes, to check what the sky is doing."
"You can bring your teddy. Teddy wants to see the clouds."

A meltdown when the screen turns off Day 13

"You're so mad. It's hard when a show ends."
"I'm right here. The tablet will be back tomorrow after nap."

More plain words

When you're too tired to play (words for your child) Day 14

"I'm very tired today. Let's do a lying-down play."
"You be the doctor. Check my knees!"

When your child doesn't answer Day 15

(Wait. Smile. Count to five in your head.)
"You're thinking. I'll wait." Then answer any look, point or sound.

Instead of quizzing Day 16

Instead of "What color is that?" try "You picked the red one."
Instead of "What's this?" try "A spoon. You're banging the spoon."

Instead of correcting Day 17

Child: "Doggy go." You: "Yes! The doggy's going. Going home."
Child: "I goed." You: "You went! You went down the big slide."

When your child wants both Day 18

"You want both! Pick one now. The other one is for after lunch."
"You choose, or I'll choose. Which?"

When their play seems "wrong" Day 19

(Instead of fixing it) "The cars are on the table! They're having a party?"
"Show me how it works."

When you feel silly singing Day 20

(To yourself) "My child doesn't need a good singer. They need me."
"I don't know all the words. Let's make them up!"

When they want the same book again (and again) Day 21

"Again? Yes! This is a good one."
"This time, you say the last word."

"Can I have your phone?" while waiting Day 22

"My phone is staying in my bag. Let's play I spy until the food comes."
"You can pick: I spy or napkin drawing?"

"Are we there yet?" Day 23

"Not yet. Let's count ten red cars, then I'll tell you how far."
"About two songs long. Which song first?"

When your child sees you on your phone Day 24

"I'm checking the weather for tomorrow. Done! Phone's going in its spot."
"Give me one minute to finish this message, then I'm all yours."

"Everyone else gets to!" Day 25

"It might be true that lots of kids do. In our family, shows have a set time."
"I want to hear what you think. Let's talk about it at dinner."

When siblings fight over whose turn it is Day 26

"Two kids, one truck. That's hard. Timer turns: you first, then you."
"While you wait, you can be the driver's helper."

More plain words

Talking to a grandparent or sitter

Day 27

"We're trying more play at home. Here are three things she loves right now."

"When shows finish, we say 'Night-night, tablet'. It helps if it sounds the same."

On a sick or travel day

Day 28

"You're sick today, so it's a cozy movie day. Tomorrow we go back to our usual plan."

"Long flight today! Shows after the first snack."

Asking your child what they liked

Day 29

"What was the most fun thing we played this month?"

"What should we play more of?"

Explaining the family plan going forward

Day 30

"This is our family's plan. Screens after nap, and lots of play."

"We'll look at it again next month and change what we need to."

"Just five more minutes!"

"You want more. It's hard to stop. Two more minutes, then night-night, tablet."

Your child grabs the device

"I won't let you grab. The tablet is asleep. You can hold my hand or hold teddy."

A friend's house has different rules

"Different homes have different plans. At home, screens are after nap."

Your child asks why grown-ups get phones

"Good question. I use mine for work and bills. I'm trying to park it more, too."

Screen time was a lifesaver today (to yourself)

"That helped us today. Tomorrow the spot is back where it lives."

A visitor offers your child their phone

"That's kind! We're doing more play right now. Want to see her block tower?"

A video call ends and your child wants more

"Bye-bye, Grandma! Let's draw her a picture to send."

Your child is upset they missed the screen spot

"You're sad we were out at show time. Tomorrow the spot is back. Want a story now?"

Our own plays

draw it!

OUR OWN PLAY

From

Prep

Mess

You need:

How to play

Talk while you play

Easier

Harder

Safety

draw it!

OUR OWN PLAY

From

Prep

Mess

You need:

How to play

Talk while you play

Easier

Harder

Safety

Questions parents ask

What exactly do I get?

Thirty short daily lessons by email (each takes about three minutes to read), one easy play a day, plain words for tricky moments, a designed workbook with trackers (US Letter and A4, color and low-ink, fillable in free Acrobat Reader), a bank of extra scripts and a certificate to celebrate.

Is there any video, coaching or calls?

No. It's a written program you do at your own pace. There are no videos to watch, no calls and no live sessions. We don't offer personal replies or advice about individual children.

What ages is it for?

Families with children aged about 1 to 5. Every play has a starting age, an easier version for toddlers and a harder version for preschoolers, and every week has boxes for toddlers, preschoolers and siblings. For a baby under 1, our 100 Screen-Free Plays book starts from birth.

What if I miss a day?

Nothing breaks. Each lesson waits in your inbox and in the workbook. Pick up wherever you are. It's fine to take longer than 30 days.

Do we have to give up screens?

No. The program adds play and talk and gives screens a steady spot in the day. Screens are never used as a reward or a punishment.

Will this change how my child talks or behaves?

It isn't designed to treat or change anything about your child. It's parent education about everyday play and talk. If you have questions about your child's development, talk with your pediatrician.

Do I need to buy anything?

No. Every play uses things most homes already have: socks, boxes, pots, books, paper.

More answers live in the help center at playbeforepixels.com/help. We don't offer personal replies or advice about individual children.

What is the guarantee?

If the program isn't right for your family, email us within 14 days of purchase for a full refund, as long as you've completed no more than 30% of the lessons. After that, course fees are non-refundable, but you keep every lesson email and the workbook files. If a file won't open or print, or you were charged twice, we fix it or refund it. The full terms are in our refund policy.

How is it delivered?

Right after checkout you get a welcome email with your workbook download. Then one lesson arrives each day for 30 days. Missed one? Every lesson is also in the workbook.

Can a classroom, child-care center, library or PTA use it?

Not yet. This purchase is for one household. Classroom, child-care, library and group licenses are not available yet.

Is there a Spanish edition?

Not yet. The program is in English. Say every talk line and script in your own words and your own language, and swap any song for one your family knows.

Can I give it as a gift?

Yes. At checkout, enter the email address of the family you're giving it to, so the welcome email and the lessons go straight to them.

Can I share it with my co-parent or a grandparent?

Yes, anyone in your household can use it. Forward the emails to your co-parent. For other families, please share the link instead of the files.

Is there a print version?

You can print the whole workbook at home, in color or low-ink, US Letter or A4. A black-and-white paperback is planned for Amazon; we'll say so here when it's out.

SOURCES

Where the research lines come from

This program uses research sparingly and in plain words. Studies that find a link between two things do not show that one causes the other.

- **World Health Organization (2019).** Guidelines on physical activity, sedentary behaviour and sleep for children under 5 years of age. (Days 2 and 12)
- **American Academy of Pediatrics, Council on Communications and Media (2016).** Media and Young Minds. *Pediatrics*, 138(5). (Day 3)
- **Brushe ME, et al. (2024).** Screen time and parent–child talk when children are aged 12 to 36 months. *JAMA Pediatrics*, 178(4), 369–375. (Day 2)
- **Delgado P, et al. (2018).** Don't throw away your printed books: a meta-analysis on the effects of reading media on reading comprehension. *Educational Research Review*, 25, 23–38. (Day 21)

Plain-words talk moves

The six talk moves in this program are described in everyday words. They are not taken from, or endorsed by, any named program.

Not medical advice

This program is parent education. It does not diagnose, treat or prevent any condition. For questions about your child's health or development, talk with your pediatrician.

WHAT'S NEXT

More from Play Before Pixels



100 Screen-Free Plays

Paperback and printable guide for ages 0–5, sorted by age.



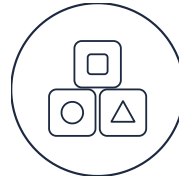
76 "I'm Bored" Play Cards

Age-banded play cards with a talk prompt on each.



Play-First Family Kit

Screen rhythm chart, family play plan, helping jobs and more.



Toddler Busy Book

74 printable activities for ages 1–5.



FREE BONUS

Keep going: a free monthly play email

Visit playbeforepixels.com/bonus/course-screen-reset for three new plays for your child's age each month. We ask only for your email and your child's birth month and year, never a name.

Know a family who would enjoy this? Share the free starter plays at playbeforepixels.com/bonus/course-screen-reset.